Difficult clients: experience and an example response

My experience

At Newcastle City Business Centre, I handled difficult client and building situations in a senior role. These included distressed inmate calls, upset medico-legal appointment attendees and meeting-room users, accessibility complaints, requests for rent reductions, and people entering other floors and harassing private tenants. I arranged for disruptive visitors to leave or called police when needed to protect staff and tenants.

One situation involved a tenant yelling at me after I interrupted their client session because of noise. I remained professional and represented the business well. This account describes my experience; the response below is an example of how I would handle a comparable situation, rather than a transcript of that incident.

Example response

The tenant is upset about the interruption. I would acknowledge the effect on their appointment, explain the reason briefly and move the discussion away from their client where possible.

> “I understand the interruption affected your appointment, and I’m sorry for that disruption. I needed to address the noise because it was affecting others in the building. I’d like to understand what happened and agree how we can avoid another interruption. Could we discuss this privately once your session finishes? I’m happy to work through the concern, but I need us to speak respectfully.”

I would adapt the wording to the person and situation. A distressed caller needs a different response from someone threatening staff.

Actions and follow-through

1. **Assess safety.** If there is a threat, follow the safety procedure, get support and contact police or emergency services when necessary. Staff should have clear authority to seek help.
2. **Listen and clarify.** Establish what happened, what the person needs and which part of the issue the business can address. Avoid arguing about their motives or making promises before checking the facts.
3. **Explain the boundary.** State the relevant noise, access or conduct requirement calmly and explain the next practical step. Professional advice and outcomes outside the business’s control go to the responsible provider.
4. **Offer an appropriate remedy.** Use an apology, practical adjustment, discount or fee waiver only where justified and within agreed authority. Explain what needs approval and when the person will receive an answer.
5. **Follow through.** Record the concern, the action owner and the promised follow-up. Check whether the agreed action was completed and escalate unresolved issues.

What I would improve as the business grows

With experience, I could recognise appropriate remedies, but each step still required owner approval. I would like to earn authority within agreed limits so routine problems can be resolved promptly and consistently.

I would use recurring complaints to improve service information, handovers, accessibility guidance and staff procedures. Onboarding should include difficult-client examples, guided practice, escalation rules and a check that staff can apply them. Progress can be measured through completed follow-ups, repeat complaints and resolution time once a baseline is established.